

SLOW PROGRESS
Conservation efforts have been painstaking but often questionable in approach, and done in isolation rather than in concert with all stakeholders

ROCK-CUT CAVES ARE "A SPECIAL COMPONENT OF INDIAN ARCHITECTURAL HISTORY". THEY CALL FOR LONG-TERM VISION AND MULTILATERAL OVERSIGHT, NOT MONOLITHIC CONTROL

started in 2006. Costs doubled over six years, from 1,303 million yen to 2,614 million yen—Rs 125 crore, nearly half of the 6,490 million yen disbursed on all Phase II projects. But a diverse dramatis personae enlivened the endeavour. Larsen & Toubro, Tata Consultancy, Chhaya and Chhaya for the design, apparently even the good people at Ramoji Rao Studios, sundry architects, researchers, contractors made their presentations (and their money). The results are impressive: even if its polycarbonate-sheeted central stupa looks more like an atomic reactor. Its underside is a massive concave film screen, furnished with a fish-eye projector and big Bose speakers set around a sleek, vast amphitheatre. Four lifesize cave replicas—RCC-Styrofoam-corn mix standing in for basalt—host giant bromide reproductions of the murals, exactly as they are. Conference halls, library, a roomy cafeteria or two. It was part of the Incredible India story back then.

It still is. It's been lying *closed*...since 2017. The gathered dust billowed up in an unusual burst of activity in mid-February, though—a long-overdue spring-cleaning. The G20 was coming! The whole sector was alive: floral designs bloomed under Aurangabad's arterial flyovers, and bulldozers were flattening shops outside Ellora's gates. As a frantic PWD missed the deadline to smoothen the last stretch of asphalt to Ajanta, someone thought of flying down the delegates via chopper—almost fulfilling the words of Fa Hien, who had said in the early fifth century that the roads were so "perilous" that locals always saw visitors *flying* to Ajanta. Finally, the rich bird life here stayed undisturbed. The plan was cancelled, and the genteel posse of Women20 returned after being treated to the G20 hologram playing on Ellora's exquisite facades.

THE IMPLEMENTATION GAPS

The caves were built so that only diffused daylight enters—no direct sunrays. The many reports on Ajanta that move in opaque corridors rarely see any daylight either. The NEERI report of 2015 is in the safe almirahs of ASI. Its later studies, under the CSIR's Heritage Mission, might as well be rare manuscripts. JICA's periodic self-audits of its three-decade hand-holding are online: its terse observations, slipped in between goody-goody language, are classics of understatement (*"There was no information provided for the administration cost,"* says the footnote to a 2017 table). In a 2007 report, JICA wrote that the local ASI manager does not know tourism management, and the local MTDC manager does not know heritage management. This cuts close to the bone. These are the two hands on the job—and forget integrated management, they simply do not talk to each other much. MTDC's domain starts where ASI's ends, at the ticket office, and while its local officials are courteous, the overall policy seems seriously remiss. The Visitor Centre is just one example. Having pushed all local small business to the grotty 'shopping plaza' two miles away in 2002, it monopolises revenue and, by all accounts, sucks it all back to Mumbai. Syed Mumtaz Husain opened the first bookshop near Ajanta in 1975, now his son sells tacky bric-a-brac from the new site—"the money has halved". All the pious talk about tourism vivifying the local economy bounces off corridors in New Delhi and stays on Unesco's elegant dossiers.

That seems another placid world, full of good intentions moving at a glacial pace. "The World Heritage Committee's (WHC) rules have themselves been evolving," explains conservator Shikha Jain of Dronah Foundation, presently rapporteur for the WHC. "A Retrospective Statement of Universal Value (RSOUV) was made mandatory in 2009 for all sites inscribed earlier. That's what led to the spurt of site management plans." Abha Narain Lambah's plan for Ajanta was ready a dozen years ago; based on that, conservator Radhika Dhumal confirms she did the